

Jainism — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Canonical ownership controls conflicts. The primary sequence is exactly ten Jainism-owned PYQs from 2018–2026. The Cārvāka-owned comparison is retained separately as Supporting S1.

Directive and timed-answer framework

| Marks | Exact band | Recommended architecture |

| ---:|---:|---:|

| 10 | 150–200 words | definition → mechanism → evaluation |

| 15 | 250–300 words | thesis → distinctions → objection/reply → verdict |

| 20 | 340–400 words | conceptual derivation → detail → criticism → graded conclusion |

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Current canonical primary sequence

Verified wording and status. The ten numbered questions below are the complete Jainism-primary sequence for 2018–2026. Wording and marks follow the verified ledgers exactly. Every model is independent learner practice, not an official UPSC key.

Ownership. Primary numbering is reserved for Jainism-owned questions. The Cārvāka-owned 2020 comparison appears separately as Supporting S1 and is not counted among the ten primary questions.

Word bands used. 10 marks: 150–200 words. 15 marks: 250–300 words. 20 marks: 340–400 words.

TEN PRIMARY JAINISM PYQS — COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Primary PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q6(c) · 15 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the Jaina philosophers explain 'bondage'? What, according to them, is the distinction between 'liberated soul' and 'bound soul'? What do the Jainas think about the condition of the 'liberated soul'? Discuss.

Demand decoded. Three explicit demands under a "Discuss" directive: the mechanism of bondage, the contrast between two classes of soul, and the positive condition of the liberated soul. Answer all three in order; the third is the one most scripts omit.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Jaina bondage is a real material event, not a moral metaphor. The soul is intrinsically endowed with infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power, yet in embodied life these stand obscured. That obscuration requires a binding factor, and Jainism identifies it as action-matter (karma-pudgala), a subtle form of matter drawn to the soul.

The mechanism runs through five causes: wrong vision, non-restraint, carelessness, passions and activity. Activity of body, speech and mind opens the channel of influx (āsrava) and determines the type and quantity of karma bound; passion supplies the adhesion and determines its duration and intensity. Bondage therefore has two faces: psychic bondage (bhāva-bandha), the soul's own passionate modification, and material bondage (dravya-bandha), the actual adhesion of karmic particles. The relation is beginningless (anādi) but not endless.

The bound soul (baddha-jīva) is thus an embodied, karmically conditioned knower whose native capacities are veiled and whose body, status, lifespan and felt experience are determined by the non-destructive karmas. The liberated soul (mukta-jīva) is one from which stoppage (saṃvara) has excluded fresh influx and shedding (nirjarā) has removed the accumulated deposit, so that nothing foreign remains.

On its condition, the Jainas are precise. The liberated soul is a perfected soul (siddha): disembodied, activity-free, beyond rebirth, and manifesting the infinite tetrad in full. Crucially it retains numerical individuality; there is no merger into a universal consciousness as in Advaita, and no dissolution as in accounts of no-self. Being unweighted by karmic matter it rises to the summit of the world (siddha-śīlā).

The account is internally coherent, though the interaction of formless soul and subtle matter remains its contested joint.

Question, exact verified wording: How is reality defined by the Jainas? How is this theory of reality reflected in their view on judgements? Discuss.

Demand decoded. The hinge word is "reflected". The examiner wants a derivation, not two separate essays. Define reality first; then show that the theory of judgement follows from that definition rather than accompanying it.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The Jainas define the real (sat) as that which possesses origination (utpāda), decay (vyaya) and persistence (dhrauvya) together. The definition is chosen to save two facts that rival definitions sacrifice. Pure permanence cannot explain that a bracelet became a ring; pure flux cannot explain why this is recognised as the same gold. Indexing permanence to substance (dravya) and change to mode (paryāya), with quality (guṇa) as the abiding characteristic, secures both.

From this follows many-sidedness (anekāntavāda): the real is ananta-dharmātmakaṃ vastu, a thing constituted by innumerable aspects. Its ontology is pluralist — six substances, of which five are extended, and innumerable souls — and its causation is correspondingly qualified, the effect being continuous with the cause as substance and novel as mode.

The reflection in judgement is strict rather than analogical. Ordinary cognition is kṣāyopāśamika, arising from the partial destruction-cum-subsidence of knowledge-obscuring karma; it is therefore necessarily partial. A judgement by a non-omniscient knower captures an aspect, not the whole. That yields standpoint theory (nayavāda), and the tradition classifies seven standpoints, running from the mixed practical view through the generic, the particular and the present-state view to the three increasingly literal verbal standpoints. A standpoint that denies the remaining aspects ceases to be a standpoint and becomes its perversion (nayābhāsa), which is the technical form of one-sidedness (ekāntavāda).

Because judgement is standpoint-bound, assertion must carry the operator syāt: conditional predication (syādvāda). Combining affirmation, negation and inexpressibility under that operator, taken singly, pairwise and jointly, yields exactly seven predications (saptabhaṅgī) — three plus three plus one. Opposed predications are indexed to substance, place, time and mode, so existence is asserted in own-form and non-existence in other-form; contradiction would require identity of respect, which the operator excludes.

Thus the theory of judgement is not an ornament on the theory of reality but its epistemic consequence: because the object exceeds any single finite judgement, and because the knower is karmically partial, unconditioned assertion is available only to omniscience (kevala-jñāna).

The derivation is powerful, though Śaṃkara's residual objection — that a doctrine which qualifies even itself weakens its assertoric force — is not fully removed.

Primary PYQ 3 · 2020 · Q5(a) · 10 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Examine the concept of Karma according to Jainism. How does it bear upon their conception of Liberation?

Demand decoded. "Examine" asks for accurate componential analysis, and the second sentence demands the causal link. A definition without the bearing scores half.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

For Jainism, action and moral consequence is not an unseen quality of the self, as in Nyāya adṛṣṭa, nor a ritual potency as in Mīmāṃsā apūrva, nor a mental impression as in Buddhist vāsanā. It is subtle matter (karma-pudgala) that flows toward the soul and adheres to it. Psychological action-matter (bhāva-karma), the soul's passionate modification, attracts material action-matter (dravya-karma).

Adhesion is analysed under four parameters: activity fixes the type and quantity bound, while passion fixes the duration and intensity. Eight karma-types divide into four destructive, which obscure knowledge, perception, right orientation and power, and four non-destructive, which determine felt experience, body, status and lifespan.

The bearing on liberation (mokṣa) is direct. Since bondage is a real deposit, liberation is subtraction and not acquisition: stoppage (saṃvara) closes the channel and shedding (nirjarā) removes the accumulation. Destroying the destructive karmas yields omniscience while still embodied; exhausting the non-destructive karmas yields the perfected soul.

Liberation therefore reveals what the soul always was, rather than conferring anything new.

Primary PYQ 4 · 2021 · Q7(c) · 15 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Explain the Jaina view of seven-fold (sapta-bhaṅgī) 'Naya'.

Demand decoded. The printed wording fuses two distinct doctrines — the sevenfold predication and standpoint theory. A safe answer explains both and expressly distinguishes them, rather than assuming the fusion is doctrinally correct.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The printed phrase joins two doctrines that Jaina authors keep apart, so both must be explained. Standpoint theory (nayavāda) concerns perspectives; the sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) concerns propositional forms.

Standpoint theory holds that every ordinary judgement expresses a naya, a partial but legitimate view of a many-sided real. The classical seven are: the mixed practical or purposive standpoint (naigama); the generic standpoint (saṃgraha); the practical particular standpoint (vyavahāra); the present-state standpoint (rjśūtra); the verbal standpoint (śabda); the etymological standpoint (samabhirūḍha); and the function-in-act standpoint (evambhūta), on which a person counts as a singer only while singing. The list narrows from loosest to strictest; the first three are substance-directed, the last three mode-directed and verbal, with the present-state view as the hinge.

The sevenfold predication is generated differently. Three primitives — affirmation, negation and inexpressibility — taken singly, in pairs and jointly yield exactly seven forms: syād asti; syān nāsti; syād asti ca nāsti ca; syād avaktavyam; syād asti ca avaktavyam; syān nāsti ca avaktavyam; and syād asti ca nāsti ca avaktavyam. Each is governed by the operator syāt, which states the respect and does not mean "perhaps".

The two are related but not identical: standpoints supply the respects; predications express them in disciplined sentential form. Contradiction is avoided because opposed predications are indexed to different substance, place, time or mode. Inexpressibility marks a limit of simultaneous unqualified expression, not a third truth-value.

The doctrine is therefore a theory of conditioned assertion rather than of doubt, though critics from Śaṃkara onward hold that permanent qualification dilutes assertoric force.

Primary PYQ 5 · 2022 · Q5(d) · 10 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How does Jaina view of Karma bear upon their soteriology? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. Same subject-matter as 2020 Q5(a), but the directive adds "critically": the answer must end with an evaluation, not a description.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Because Jaina action-matter is literally material, soteriology becomes a physics of removal rather than a programme of moral improvement. Activity opens the influx channel and fixes what and how much is bound; passion fixes how long and how strongly it fruits. Hence passion-free activity produces only momentary bondage (īryāpathika), whereas passion-coloured activity produces durable bondage (sāmparāyika).

Two remedies follow, because bondage has two problems. Stoppage (saṃvara), operated through the vows, restraint, carefulness, the virtues, contemplations and endurance of afflictions, blocks fresh influx. Shedding (nirjarā), operated chiefly through austerity, exhausts what is already bound. Merit does not substitute for either, since even good karma keeps the soul in the cycle of rebirth.

Critically, the doctrine gains real explanatory precision: it grounds an ethics of intention in a causal mechanism, and it explains graded spiritual progress. Its cost is equally real. Nyāya presses that material karma cannot intelligibly bind a formless consciousness, and a Cārvāka denies the whole apparatus as unverifiable.

The account is therefore coherent within Jaina ontology, not demonstrable outside it.

Primary PYQ 6 · 2022 · Q6(b) · 15 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: 'The doctrine of Relativism of Jain Philosophy cannot be logically sustained without postulating 'Absolutism'.' Critically examine this view and give reasons in the favour of your answer.

Demand decoded. A stated view must be engaged, not paraphrased. Locate the equivocation, give the Jaina reply, then take a reasoned position and state what survives.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The quoted view rests on an equivocation between two senses of "absolute". Jaina non-absolutism (anekāntavāda) denies one-sided exclusivism by finite knowers; it does not deny that comprehensive knowledge is possible. Once the two are separated, the alleged self-contradiction dissolves.

The charge runs: the doctrine claims universal scope; universal scope appears absolute; therefore the doctrine covertly relies on what it attacks. The Jaina reply is threefold. First, the doctrine is itself asserted syāt, so it obeys its own rule; reflexive qualification exhibits the discipline it teaches rather than exempting itself from it. Second, the thesis is not that all judgements are equally true but that truth is aspect-conditioned, so judgements remain gradable by whether they respect their own conditions. Third, within the system omniscience (kevala-jñāna) is the internal case of complete knowledge, available when knowledge-obscuring karma is destroyed; ordinary discourse remains standpoint-bound because ordinary cognition is kṣāyopaśamika.

It should also be said that "relativism" mislabels the position. Jainism is ontologically realist: the aspects are objectively in the thing, and only finite access to them is partial. Relativism relativises truth; non-absolutism relativises exclusive claims.

Critically, the reply succeeds against the charge as printed but does not leave the field untouched. The unconditioned status has been relocated rather than abolished: omniscience now carries the completeness that finite discourse is denied. A critic may say this concedes the substance of the objection at a higher level.

My position is therefore qualified agreement with the Jaina: the doctrine is logically sustainable and not self-refuting, but it is not standpoint-free, and honesty requires saying that its consistency is purchased by admitting one privileged cognitive state.

Primary PYQ 7 · 2023 · Q5(a) · 10 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: "All human knowledge is empirical and therefore relative." Critically examine Jaina theory of sevenfold judgement (saptabhaṅgīnaya) in the light of above statement.

Demand decoded. The quoted proposition is an empiricist thesis. The task is to test whether the sevenfold judgement is an instance of it, and to show precisely where Jainism agrees and where it refuses.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Jainism agrees with half of the statement and rejects the other half. It agrees that human knowledge is limited: ordinary cognition is kṣāyopaśamika, partial because knowledge-obscuring karma is only partly removed, and ordinary perception is only conventionally direct.

It refuses the inference to relativism. The sevenfold judgement — the seven forms generated by affirmation, negation and inexpressibility under the operator syāt — records the respects in which a predication holds, using the indices of substance, place, time and mode. Each form is a definite assertion, not a probability estimate; syāt does not mean "perhaps".

Critically, the difference from empiricist relativism is ontological. For the empiricist, relativity attaches to knowledge because there is no access beyond experience. For Jainism, relativity attaches to finite judgement while the aspects remain objectively in the object, and omniscience remains internally possible.

Hence the statement describes a Jaina premise, not a Jaina conclusion: partiality of knowing does not entail relativity of truth.

Primary PYQ 8 · 2024 · Q6(c) · 15 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: What is the distinction between Bhāva-bandha and Dravya-bandha, according to the Jainas? Discuss.

Demand decoded. A single precise distinction, discussed. The answer must state both terms exactly, show their causal order, and explain why Jainism refuses to collapse them.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Jaina bondage has two forms which are distinct in nature yet inseparable in operation.

Psychic bondage (bhāva-bandha) is a modification of the soul itself. Through passion, attachment, aversion, delusion and wrong disposition the soul undergoes an affective-volitional deformation. This is a state of the conscious substance, describable in the vocabulary of moral psychology.

Material bondage (dravya-bandha) is the actual adhesion of karmic particles. Because matter alone possesses form, and because the embodied soul has space-points and is co-extensive with its body, subtle matter can be attracted and fixed. This is an event in the ontology of substances, not a description of an attitude.

The causal order is fixed: psychical action-matter (bhāva-karma) attracts material action-matter (dravya-karma). Inner deformation precedes and shapes outer adhesion. This is why the four parameters divide as they do — activity determines the type and quantity of matter bound, whereas passion, which is a psychic condition, determines duration and intensity. A monk's careful walking binds momentarily; an angry act binds deeply.

Jainism refuses to collapse the pair because each carries something the other cannot. Retain only psychic bondage and karma becomes a metaphor, leaving the obscuration of an intrinsically omniscient soul unexplained. Retain only material bondage and the system becomes crude physicalism in which intention is irrelevant to moral consequence.

The distinction also organises the path: stoppage works primarily on the psychic side by removing the causes of influx, while shedding works on the material deposit already formed.

Critically, the pairing preserves both agency and ontology, though the interaction of a formless soul with subtle matter — the very point Nyāya attacks — remains the doctrine's unresolved joint.

Primary PYQ 9 · 2025 · Q7(c) · 15 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Is Jaina philosophy pluralistic and realistic? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. Two labels, both to be tested. "Critically" requires that each be affirmed with the correct qualifier rather than simply endorsed.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Jaina philosophy is strongly pluralistic and realistic, but its realism must be described as qualified.

It is pluralistic in three independent ways. Ontologically it admits six substances — soul, matter, medium of motion, medium of rest, space and time — of which five are extended. Psychologically it admits innumerable souls, each beginningless and numerically distinct. Soteriologically it holds that liberation produces many perfected souls at the summit of the world, with no merger into any absolute. Monistic reduction is refused at every level.

It is realistic in that substances, qualities and modes are objectively real; the external world is not appearance; and knowledge aims at real objects. Aspects are in the thing, not projected onto it, which is why many-sidedness (anekāntavāda) is an ontological thesis before it is a logical one.

The qualifier is epistemic. Because finite cognition is kṣāyopaśamika and therefore partial, judgement is standpoint-indexed and assertion carries the operator syāt. This yields the decisive formula: qualification of knowledge does not entail unreality of the object. Ontological realism and epistemic non-absolutism are separable, and Jainism holds both.

Critically, two costs deserve statement. First, Rāmānuja objects that a real substance bearing opposed real attributes is unintelligible, and a Dharmakīrti-style Buddhist presses that a permanent-yet-changing soul fails the test of causal efficacy; the Jaina reply, that the opposition is between aspects of substance and mode, persuades only those who already grant aspect-realism. Second, the pluralism is metaphysically expensive, requiring material action-matter and intrinsically omniscient souls that a Cārvāka will reject as unverifiable.

The defensible verdict is therefore that Jainism is genuinely pluralistic and genuinely realistic, but its realism is qualified realism rather than naive realism.

Primary PYQ 10 · 2026 · Q7(b) · 15 marks · Jainism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Explain the meaning of seven steps of judgement (Saptabhanginaya) and its application in Jaina's Syadvada for advocating a philosophy of non-absolutism (Anekantavada).

Demand decoded. Explain all seven forms, locate them within syādvāda, and derive their non-absolutist force from anekāntavāda without calling the doctrine relativism.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Jaina non-absolutism begins from anekāntavāda, the ontological thesis that a real possesses many aspects and combines persistence with changing modes. A finite knower therefore grasps an aspect rather than the exhaustive object. Nayavāda analyses those legitimate but partial standpoints; syādvāda disciplines the assertion made from them. The particle syāt means "from a specified respect," not "perhaps." Seven predications arise from affirmation, negation and inexpressibility, singly and in combination: in some respect it is; it is not; it is and is not; it is inexpressible; it is and is inexpressible; it is not and is inexpressible; and it is, is not

and is inexpressible. “Is” and “is not” concern different indices of substance, place, time or mode, so the law of non-contradiction is preserved. Inexpressibility marks the inability to state opposed, qualified aspects simultaneously in one unqualified expression; it is not a third truth-value. The application is illustrated by a clay pot: it exists as its present pot-mode, does not exist as cloth or as a past lump-mode, persists as clay, and resists a single exhaustive assertion. Thus saptabhaṅginaya translates a many-sided ontology into conditional predication. It avoids dogmatic one-sidedness without endorsing relativism or “anything goes,” because each claim remains answerable to a real object and a stated respect. Its strength is disciplined pluralism; its difficulty is whether endlessly qualifying assertions weakens their force. The Jaina reply is that qualification increases precision rather than abolishing truth. This reinforces the Jaina integration of ontology, epistemology and disciplined liberation. This reinforces the Jaina integration of ontology, epistemology and disciplined liberation.

SUPPORTING CROSS-TOPIC PYQ — OUTSIDE PRIMARY NUMBERING

Supporting cross-topic PYQ S1 · 2020 · Q7(c) · 15 marks · Cārvāka-primary / Jainism-supporting · fully solved

Question, as printed: Explain the differences of conception of Reality between Cārvāka and Jainism.

Routing note: primary ownership rests with Cārvāka; it is solved here because the Jaina half of the contrast is owned by this topic and is the half most often written badly.

Demand decoded. “Explain the differences” is comparative and expository. Use fixed axes so that the contrast is systematic rather than anecdotal.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Cārvāka and Jainism differ on the definition of the real, on its inventory and on the reach of knowledge.

Definition. Cārvāka recognises as real only what is materially constituted and, in principle, perceptible. Jainism defines the real as that which possesses origination, decay and persistence together, so permanence and change are equally real in one thing, indexed to substance and mode.

Inventory. Cārvāka admits four elements — earth, water, fire and air — and characteristically rejects ether. Jainism admits six substances, five of them extended, including a conscious substance and two cosmological media that Cārvāka has no use for. Where Cārvāka has one kind of stuff, Jainism has an irreducibly plural ontology.

Consciousness. For Cārvāka, awareness emerges from the organised body, so the living body qualified by consciousness is the self. For Jainism, consciousness is the defining quality of an independent soul, and there are innumerable such souls, intrinsically endowed with infinite knowledge that karma obscures.

Moral consequence and liberation. Cārvāka rejects action-consequence, rebirth and liberation. Jainism makes action-matter literally material, so bondage is a real deposit and liberation is its removal.

Knowledge. Cārvāka restricts valid knowledge to perception and refuses inference independent standing. Jainism accepts inference and testimony as indirect, treats ordinary perception as only conventionally direct, and grades knowledge up to omniscience.

The deepest difference is methodological. Cārvāka's ontology contracts to fit one means of knowledge; Jainism's theory of knowledge expands to fit a many-sided reality. One shrinks the world to secure certainty; the other qualifies assertion to preserve the world's complexity.

Original coverage-driven timed practice

The formal workbook's six original models are preserved verbatim below. Their selection is doctrine-driven: ontology/judgement, epistemology, standpoint/predication, bondage, liberation and inter-school criticism. Together with the ten PYQs, every major doctrine has a timed model.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE — SIX MODELS

These six questions are original practice items written in UPSC style. They are not previous-year questions and are not represented as such.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between many-sidedness (anekāntavāda), standpoint theory (nayavāda) and conditional predication (syādvāda). Why is the order of derivation philosophically significant?

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

The three doctrines occupy different levels and are derived in a fixed order.

Many-sidedness is metaphysical: the real object is ananta-dharmātmakam vastu, constituted by innumerable aspects, so no single unqualified proposition exhausts it. Standpoint theory is epistemic: because finite cognition is partial, every ordinary judgement expresses a naya, one legitimate perspective among many; a standpoint that denies the rest becomes its perversion. Conditional predication is logical-linguistic: assertion must carry syāt, stating the respect in which it holds, and the sevenfold predication is its formal schema.

The order matters for two reasons. First, it makes the logic non-arbitrary. If many-sidedness came last, the syāt operator would look like a debating trick; derived first, it makes qualification obligatory. Second, it protects realism. The aspects are in the object; only access is partial. Reversing the order would make Jainism a theory about language or attitude rather than about the world.

Hence a script that names the three terms but not their levels has recited without explaining.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "In Jainism the moral quality of an act is fixed by passion rather than by activity." Examine this claim with reference to the parameters of bondage.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

The claim is accurate if stated with care. Karmic bondage is analysed under four parameters. Activity of body, speech and mind determines the type (prakṛti) of karma bound and the quantity (pradeśa) of matter bound. Passion determines the duration (sthiti) and the intensity (anubhāga) of its fruition.

Since duration and intensity are the parameters that actually decide how heavily an act weighs on the future of the soul, the moral seriousness of an act tracks passion rather than mere movement. The doctrinal expression of this is the contrast between momentary bondage from passion-free activity and durable bondage from passion-coloured activity: a monk's careful walking binds only momentarily, while an angry act binds deeply.

The claim must nevertheless be qualified. Activity is not morally irrelevant, since it fixes what is bound at all, and total cessation of activity belongs only to the fourteenth stage.

The precise formulation is therefore that activity determines the karmic content while passion determines its karmic weight.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Examine the Jaina claim that ordinary sense-perception is only conventionally direct. What does this reveal about the relation between Jaina epistemology and Jaina soteriology?

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Jainism divides valid knowledge into direct (pratyakṣa) and indirect (parokṣa), but measures directness by absence of mediation rather than by sensory vividness. Ordinary sense-perception depends on sense-organs, the mind, signs and karmic limitation. It is therefore only conventional direct knowledge (sāmvyavahārika pratyakṣa) and strictly belongs with mediated cognition. What is direct in the full sense is knowledge the soul has by itself: limited clairvoyance (avadhi), knowledge of others' mental modes (manahparyāya) and omniscience (kevala).

The claim is defensible on its own terms. It preserves ordinary life, since perception remains valid for practical dealings; it distinguishes practical adequacy from metaphysical finality; and it avoids the Nyāya assumption that sense-contact is the paradigm of directness.

What it reveals is that Jaina epistemology is not a free-standing theory. The five kinds of knowledge are stations on a single curve of karmic unveiling: mati and śruta are mediated, the remaining three progressively direct, and omniscience is the state in which knowledge-obscuring karma has been destroyed. Knowledge is therefore graded by purity, not by method.

Two consequences follow. First, conditional predication becomes obligatory rather than optional, because a kṣāyopāśamika knower cannot make an unconditioned claim. Second, wrong cognition is orientation-relative: kumatī, kuśruta and vibhaṅga are cognitions held under wrong vision, so error is a spiritual as well as a logical category.

Critically, this integration is the system's strength and its exposure. It gives Jainism a unified account of knowing and liberation, but it makes the epistemology depend on an ontology of soul and karmic matter that an empiricist critic will refuse at the outset.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "Jaina non-violence is a metaphysical consequence, not a sentiment." Critically discuss with reference to the doctrine of the soul and the mechanics of bondage.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The claim is well founded. Jaina non-violence (ahiṃsā) is derived, not asserted.

The derivation begins in ontology. Souls are innumerable and graded from one-sense immobile beings — earth-, water-, fire-, air- and plant-bodied — to five-sense mobile beings. Every one of them is a conscious substance intrinsically endowed with the infinite tetrad and currently obscured. Injury therefore falls on a knower, not on a thing.

It continues in the mechanics of bondage. Injury is characteristically produced by passion, and passion fixes the duration and intensity of karmic adhesion. Violence is thus not merely wrong by a rule; it is causally the most efficient way to deepen bondage. Non-violence, conversely, is an operation of stoppage: it closes the channel through which the heaviest karma enters.

The doctrine is graded rather than utopian. Ascetics take the great vows; householders take the lesser vows; and carefulness in movement, speech, alms-seeking, handling objects and bodily functions extends the principle into ordinary conduct. Extreme care toward one-sense beings is an implication of the ontology, not an excess of feeling.

Critically, two points deserve statement. First, the derivation is only as strong as its premises: a critic who denies that plants or elemental bodies house souls will accept the ethics while rejecting its scope. Second, the account is intention-sensitive rather than consequence-sensitive, which is a philosophical choice with costs of its own.

Nevertheless, the central contention holds: Jaina non-violence follows from plural souls and karmic mechanics, and treating it as sentiment removes precisely the argument that makes it distinctive among Indian ethical positions.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Analyse the Jaina fourteen stages of spiritual development. How do the two ladders explain spiritual relapse, and what does this show about the relation between insight and conduct in Jainism?

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The fourteen stages (guṇasthāna) map the soul's movement from false vision to final liberation, and they are graded by karmic condition rather than by external observance.

Stages one to three describe wrong, falling and mixed orientation. Stage four, right vision without restraint, is the decisive breakthrough: right vision (samyag-darśana) becomes stable enough to orient the path even though conduct has not yet followed. Stage five introduces partial restraint through lay vows. Stages six and seven mark full restraint with and then without negligence. Stages eight to ten describe progressive purification of the passions, from unprecedented purification through advanced purification to the condition in which only subtle greed remains. Stages eleven and twelve mark the crucial difference between suppression and destruction of delusion. Stage thirteen is the embodied omniscient being, and stage fourteen the momentary activity-free condition immediately preceding the perfected state.

The two ladders explain relapse without treating it as mere failure. On the ladder of suppression (upaśama-śreṇī), delusion is covered rather than removed; such a soul may reach the eleventh stage, but because suppressed delusion retains its potency the fall is necessary, not accidental. On the ladder of annihilation (kṣapaka-śreṇī), delusion is destroyed, so the twelfth stage is stable and the ascent continues to omniscience.

Three philosophical consequences follow. First, appearance and condition come apart: two souls may look identical at the tenth stage and have opposite futures, which is why Jainism refuses to identify spiritual attainment with observable conduct alone. Second, insight and conduct are interdependent rather than alternative. Right vision at stage four is genuine yet insufficient; conduct without right vision has no orientation; and the ladder records the joint operation of the three jewels. Third, omniscience is decoupled from disembodiment: destroying the destructive karmas yields omniscience at stage thirteen, while the non-destructive karmas sustain

body, status, lifespan and felt experience until the end.

Critically, an Advaita-style objection holds that a fourteen-stage ladder mechanises liberation, substituting a karmic audit for insight. The Jaina reply is that insight which does not destroy karma has not yet done its work, and that the ladder simply records the difference between a covered and a destroyed defilement.

The scheme is therefore best evaluated as a psychology of purification with an unusually honest account of relapse, and its taxonomic weight is the price of that honesty.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Jainism preserves the reality of the world at the cost of the simplicity of logic; Advaita preserves the simplicity of logic at the cost of the reality of the world." Critically examine this comparison.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The comparison is illuminating but requires correction on both sides.

On the Jaina side it is broadly accurate. Jainism refuses to treat either permanence or change as appearance. The real is defined as originating, decaying and persisting together, so both are secured — but the price is that predication must be indexed. Assertion carries the operator syāt; opposed predications are separated by substance, place, time and mode; and the exhaustive schema of qualified assertion contains seven forms rather than a simple affirmation and denial. Ontological economy is sacrificed too: six substances, innumerable souls and material action-matter are admitted because each performs explanatory work. The world is saved, and logic becomes intricate.

On the Advaita side the statement needs care. Advaita does not abandon the world; it grades it. The world is empirically real and only ultimately mithyā, and sublation, not denial, is the operative notion. What Advaita gains is a single ultimate reality with a straightforward account of contradiction: opposed characterisations belong to different levels, and the lower is finally cancelled. So the accurate formulation is that Advaita preserves logical simplicity by admitting levels of reality, whereas Jainism preserves ontological plurality by admitting respects of predication.

That reformulation locates the real difference. Both schools face the problem of apparently opposed predicates. Advaita separates them vertically, by rank, with the lower cancelled at realisation. Jainism separates them horizontally, by aspect, with nothing cancelled at all. Vertical separation buys a simple logic and requires a doctrine of appearance; horizontal separation buys an unqualified realism and requires a doctrine of conditional assertion.

Critically, each pays where the other saves. Śaṅkara charges that Jaina qualification erodes assertoric force and that a doctrine which qualifies even itself cannot claim universal scope. The Jaina replies that reflexive qualification is obedience rather than exemption, and counter-charges that treating the world as ultimately mithyā purchases simplicity by demoting the very reality it set out to explain. Neither charge is answerable from a neutral standpoint, because each presupposes what the other denies.

The defensible verdict is that the quoted comparison identifies a genuine trade-off but mislabels the Advaita side. Jainism trades logical simplicity for unqualified realism; Advaita trades ontological plurality, not the world itself, for a single unsublated real.

Major-doctrine answer spine

| Doctrine | Mandatory distinctions | Best critical move |

|---|---|---|

| Jīva/ajīva and six substances | time is a substance but not an astikāya; pudgala alone has form | explain pluralist realism |

| Karma and bondage | bhāva-bandha versus dravya-bandha; activity versus passion | explain soul–matter interaction objection |

| Liberation | āsrava → bandha → saṃvara → nirjarā → mokṣa | distinguish bound soul, embodied omniscient and siddha |

| Anekāntavāda | ontology, not a loose attitude | answer self-refutation without absolutizing |

| Nayavāda | standpoint analysis | distinguish naya from nayābhāsa |

| Syādvāda/saptabhaṅgī | conditional predication and seven forms | deny contradiction by indexed respects |

| Epistemology | direct/indirect inversion and five knowledges | connect finite cognition to qualified assertion |

| Ethics | three jewels, vows, guṇasthānas, sallekhanā | show discipline as karmic stoppage/shedding |